Write Down How Dad Manages Today So You'll Notice When It Changes

Four prompts to record an ordinary week, notice where family help has quietly grown, keep observations separate from conclusions, and decide what would prompt a conversation with a professional.

Where you are

Dad still lives in his own place and handles most things himself. Nothing has gone wrong. You've just started to wonder whether some things take him longer than they used to, and you realize you have no record to compare against.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You have a dated snapshot of what Dad does on his own and where the family already steps in, plus a short list of changes that would be worth raising with his doctor.

A one-page baseline: What Dad does on his own, Where the family already helps, What we've noticed changing, and What would prompt a conversation with a professional.

Before you start

- A few minutes thinking back over Dad's last ordinary week.
- A rough idea of which relatives or neighbors do small things for him.
- Any recent letter or summary from his doctor, if one is handy. Two of the three is plenty.

PROMPT 1

Describe an ordinary week

WHY THIS MATTERS

You'll compare against this later. A week recorded now, with a date on it, beats trying to remember next year how things used to be.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Notes on what Dad did last week, day by day if you can manage it.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I'm writing down how my father manages day to day so I have something to compare against later. Nothing is wrong right now. Here are my notes on his last ordinary week:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Turn this into a dated baseline with these headings: GETTING AROUND, MEALS AND KITCHEN, PERSONAL CARE, HOUSEHOLD AND ERRANDS, MEMORY AND MOOD, SOCIAL LIFE. Under each heading, put only what I actually described, in plain sentences. Where I said nothing, write “not noted” so I can see the blank. Do not guess at anything I left out, and do not comment on whether any of it is normal for his age.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A snapshot with blanks you can see, not a verdict.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put today's date at the top and save it somewhere you'll find it in six months.

PROMPT 2

Notice how much the family already does

WHY THIS MATTERS

Help grows a little at a time. Someone started driving him to appointments two years ago. Someone else quietly took over the bills. Nobody counts it, so nobody notices it has doubled.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A list of everything relatives, friends, or neighbors do for Dad, and roughly when each thing started.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is a list of things other people do for my father, with a rough idea of when each one began:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Sort these into three columns: HE HAS ALWAYS HAD HELP WITH THIS, HELP STARTED IN THE LAST YEAR OR TWO, and I'M NOT SURE WHEN IT STARTED. Then tell me, in a short paragraph, roughly how much help he gets in an ordinary week if you add it all up. Finally, ask me five questions about tasks I haven't mentioned at all, such as money, medications, transport, or housework.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The second column. That's where gradual change hides.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask one or two of the helpers whether your list matches what they actually do.

PROMPT 3

Separate what you saw from what you concluded

WHY THIS MATTERS

One forgotten appointment is a fact. “His memory is going” is a conclusion. Writing both down as if they were the same thing makes the baseline less useful and the worry bigger.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Anything in your first two results that sounds like a worry or a judgment.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Below are my notes about my father. Some of it is what I saw and some of it is what I think it means:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES FROM PROMPTS 1 AND 2]
>
> Make a two-column table. Left column: WHAT I OBSERVED, with each item rewritten as one specific thing that happened, with a rough date if I gave one. Right column: WHAT I CONCLUDED, with the assumption or worry it led to. If an item has only a conclusion and no specific observation behind it, say so. Don't tell me whether my conclusions are right. Don't suggest a diagnosis or what might be causing anything.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Conclusions with nothing underneath them. Those are the ones to watch rather than worry about.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

For each unsupported conclusion, decide what you would need to see to confirm it or let it go.

PROMPT 4

Agree on what would prompt a conversation

WHY THIS MATTERS

Planning ahead doesn't mean watching for everything. It means knowing which changes matter enough to call someone, so the rest of the time you can relax.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the baseline I've put together about my father:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write one page with four headings: WHAT DAD DOES ON HIS OWN, WHERE THE FAMILY ALREADY HELPS, WHAT WE'VE NOTICED CHANGING, and WHAT WOULD PROMPT A CONVERSATION WITH A PROFESSIONAL. Under the last heading, list specific, observable changes, such as a fall, a missed medication, or new difficulty with a task he does now. Next to each, note who we would likely talk to: his doctor, a pharmacist, a care consultant, or the family first. Do not rank the changes by seriousness and do not estimate how likely any of them is.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A short, specific watch list, not a list of everything that could go wrong.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Share the page with one other family member and agree to look at it again in six months, or sooner if something on the list happens.

Turn the snapshot into a profile

A baseline is only useful if it's complete. The care interview goes through Dad's situation area by area, including the parts you didn't think to write down, and saves it as a Family Care Profile you can update as things change.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›